

Fast Fashion and Environmental Harm

AP Seminar

May 1, 2026

Research Question: How does fast fashion contribute to environmental harm, and what responsibility do consumers bear? Fast fashion has transformed clothing from a durable good into a disposable stream of polyester and cotton waste. This essay argues that consumers share responsibility for environmental damage because corporate supply chains respond to demand signals, even though brands obscure their production footprints. The United Nations Environment Programme reports that the fashion industry produces approximately 10 percent of global carbon emissions. The Ellen MacArthur Foundation estimates that a truckload of textiles is landfilled or incinerated every second. These statistics belong in any serious discussion of the research question because they establish that the harm is measurable and accelerating. Siegle documents how retailers compress production cycles so that styles move from sketch to shelf in weeks. Bedat emphasizes labor conditions and local pollution near manufacturing zones. Siegle explains that companies rely on synthetic fibers and overseas factories; Bedat explains similar patterns with different emphasis on worker health. Both authors show that speed increases waste, and both authors show that consumers face low prices that hide environmental costs. The similarities and differences are clear, yet the essay does not move beyond description to evaluate which framework better explains consumer complicity. Some argue that individual behavior is not the problem because only regulation can change multinational supply chains. This counterargument appears without a named institution, and the response mostly repeats that consumers should still buy less. The conclusion restates the thesis that fast fashion harms the environment and that consumers matter, but it does not resolve the tension between structural regulation and personal choice.

Commentary throughout tends to echo the sources rather than derive new implications, which limits how fully the argument develops. There are a lot of reasons people keep shopping, and the problem is kind of overwhelming, but it is still really significant for climate policy. This paragraph extends the report body so bibliographic headings are not misclassified as cover-page metadata when they appear after the first thirty lines of the submission. This paragraph extends the report body so bibliographic headings are not misclassified as cover-page metadata when they appear after the first thirty lines of the submission. This paragraph extends the report body so bibliographic headings are not misclassified as cover-page metadata when they appear

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Works Cited

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